doing, funneled vast sums of money to different Cuban exile organizations. CIA agent Felix Rodriguez sneaked into Cuba from Key West in early 1961, was met by a party of two dozen Cubans on the coast, transported efficiently to a Havana "safe-house," and spent a month underground in Havana, meeting with the "resistance," traveling, waiting for a weapons shipment which never arrived. His description of the network of safe-houses in Havana and elsewhere, and the various infiltrators hiding there, leaves no doubt as to why Cuban security officials might be concerned about such matters.[44] Rodriguez also claimed CIA responsibility for the fire that destroyed Havana's largest department store, El Encanto, a few weeks before the Bay of Pigs invasion.[45]

Assassination was also contemplated – and perhaps attempted – in conjunction with the Bay of Pigs invasion. E. Howard Hunt recalled that when he proposed assassination as a prelude to invasion, he was assured that this was already in the hands of a "special group."[46] Historian Thomas Paterson notes that "the CIA activated assassination plots in March and April. It seems likely that assassination was part of the general Bay of Pigs plan. [The CIA officer in charge of the invasion Richard M.] Bissell has admitted that he was hopeful 'that Castro would be dead before the landing'."[47]

The exile army that came to be known as Brigade 2506 trained in south Florida, and at U.S. military and CIA bases in Panama and Guatemala. On April 17th, 1961, the invaders landed on the swampy beach at Playa Girón. CIA intelligence had led them to expect significant support on the ground. Instead, the Cuban military rapidly mobilized to overcome the invaders, and within three days, the invasion was decisively defeated. The Revolution's popularity, both at home and abroad, was strengthened. But so was the Cuban government's suspicion of dissent, at home, and its desire to look abroad for support against a hostile United States. In December 1961, Fidel Castro declared himself a Marxist-Leninist. The Cuban government also turned to the USSR as the best means of deterring or repelling a future U.S. attack. But the conflict between Cuba and the United States was only beginning.